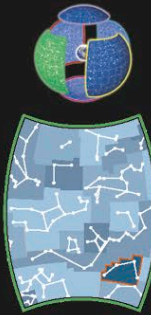


THE AIR PUMP

Antlia



SIZE RANKING	62
BRIGHTEST STAR	Alpha (α) 4.3
GENITIVE	Antliae
ABBREVIATION	Ant
HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 PM	March–April
FULLY VISIBLE	49°N–90°S

This constellation was one of those introduced in the mid-18th century by the French astronomer Nicolas Louis de Lacaille (see p.422) to commemorate scientific and technical inventions—in

this case, an air pump designed by the French physicist Denis Papin for his experiments on gases.

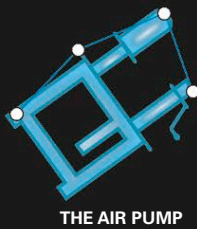
SPECIFIC FEATURES

Zeta (ζ) Antliae appears as a wide pair of 6th-magnitude stars when viewed through binoculars. The brighter of the pair has a companion of 7th magnitude.

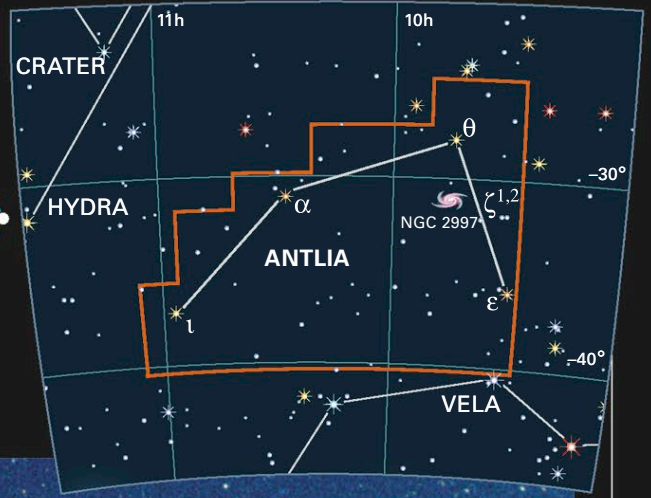
NGC 2997 is an elegant spiral galaxy inclined at about 45 degrees to our line of sight. Unfortunately, it is just too faint to be well seen through a small telescope, although it can be captured beautifully on photographs and CCD images. NGC 2997 is about 35 million light-years away.

NGC 2997 𐀔

This classic spiral galaxy reveals pink clouds of hydrogen gas dotted along its spiral arms in CCD images.



THE AIR PUMP



NORTH OF VELA 𐀔

Antlia is an inconspicuous grouping in the Southern Hemisphere and consists of a handful of stars to be found between Vela and Hydra.

THE SEXTANT

Sextans



SIZE RANKING	47
BRIGHTEST STAR	Alpha (α) 4.5
GENITIVE	Sextantis
ABBREVIATION	Sex
HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 PM	March–April
FULLY VISIBLE	78°N–83°S

Representing a sextant used for taking star positions in the days before telescopes were invented, Sextans was introduced in the late 17th century by the Polish astronomer Johannes Hevelius (see p.384), who used such a device when cataloging the stars.

SPECIFIC FEATURES

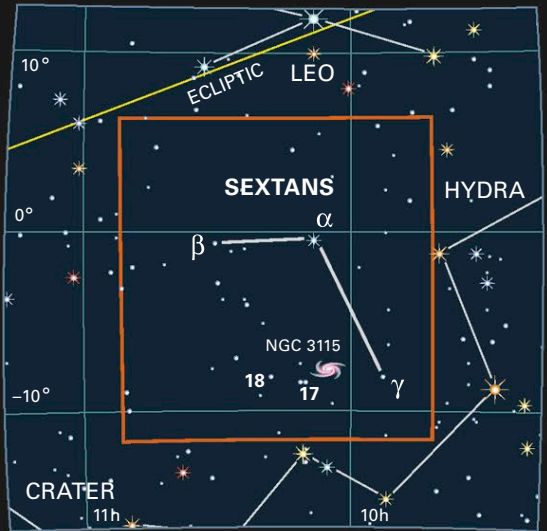
Two unrelated stars of 6th magnitude, 17 and 18 Sextantis, form a line-of-sight double star, which shows neatly through binoculars.

In the same part of the constellation lies NGC 3115, which is popularly named the Spindle Galaxy because of its highly elongated shape. This lenticular galaxy is detectable through a small telescope.



HEVELIUS'S SEXTANT 𐀔

Sextans is difficult to pick out with the naked eye because it is a faint and unremarkable constellation. It lies on the celestial equator south of Leo.



THE SEXTANT

THE SPINDLE GALAXY 𐀔

NGC 3115 is a lenticular galaxy seen edge-on from Earth, so it appears highly elliptical in shape when viewed through a telescope. It is just over 30 million light-years from us.